the outside world. Concern over the maritime frontier would become salient only in the nineteenth century, with the threat posed by Western maritime powers.

There is some similarity here with successive Indian empires centred mainly in northern India. Their security perceptions were shaped mainly by the threat of invasion from the north-west land frontier. The outlook was different from the perspective of India's southern kingdoms, which developed strong maritime forces and engaged in seaborne trade towards both the eastern and western reaches of the Indian Ocean, taking advantage of the seasonal monsoon winds. The Chola kingdom, for example, was one of the key maritime powers during the medieval period, its influence stretching as far as the Indonesian archipelago.

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The earliest Chinese kingdoms, which later coalesced into the Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE), had already had to fend off attacks from the Xiongnu tribes to the north and west. The first fortifications to protect their kingdoms were later linked together and extended during Qin rule to serve as the Great Wall of China. The Qin had defeated the Xiongnu, who retreated into what is now Mongolia. The area captured from them, the Ordos Loop, is a piece of elevated terrain encompassed by a rectangular bend of the Yellow River in its middle reaches. It is here that the more elaborate walled fortifications were built to defend the Ordos Loop. The Xiongnu continued to harass and threaten the succeeding Han dynasty (132 BCE –89 CE) until they were finally defeated and forced to retreat deeper into Mongolia.

There were other nomadic tribes associated with the Xiongnu, prominent among them being the Xianbei. One of their branches, the Tuoba, were active on the frontiers of the Tang dynasty (618–907 CE) which occupied the heartland but expanded towards the west from its capital Changan (modern Xian). The Tang also faced attacks by the expanding empire of the Tibetans who, in one of their expeditions, even captured the Tang capital. The main trade routes across Central Asia passed through the well-known Hexi corridor, which is also known as the Gansu corridor. It is a narrow